

Value & Contrast Control

Designing where attention goes

Value contrast is the most powerful compositional tool in drawing. Where you place your highest contrast determines where the eye goes. Learning to control this is learning to direct the viewer's experience.

KEY CONCEPTS

Focal Point Contrast

Place your darkest dark adjacent to your lightest light at the center of interest. This creates maximum contrast and draws the eye there first. Everything else in the drawing should have less contrast.

Contrast Gradients

The contrast in your drawing should gradually decrease as you move away from the focal point. Edges soften, values come closer together, detail decreases. This gradient creates a sense of atmosphere and depth.

Squint Test

Squint at your drawing until everything blurs. What you see is the value design. Is the focal point clearly the highest contrast area? If multiple areas compete for attention, simplify the lesser ones.

Value Notan

Notan (Japanese concept) is the harmony of dark and light as flat shapes. A good notan design works as an abstract black-and-white pattern. Draw the notan before drawing the subject — it will guide all your value decisions.

PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a portrait with one spot of extreme contrast and everything else soft.
 2. Do a notan sketch of your composition before starting the full drawing.
 3. Apply the squint test to 5 drawings in your sketchbook. Note what the value design communicates.
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FURTHER READING

■ Ctrl+Paint – Contrast

<https://www.ctrlpaint.com/videos/contrast>

■ Proko – Notan